In February 2014, the president requested the legislature to draft the controversial bills on religious conversion, interfaith marriage, population control, and polygamy, popularly known as the *myo-saunt-upade* (laws on protection of race and religion). Instead of drafting these bills, the legislature returned the ball back to the executive by suggesting that these bills be drafted by the respective government agencies and they submit them to the legislature. This was a smart move by the Speaker Thura Shwe Mann, because it prevented ultra-nationalist lawmakers and groups from influencing the drafting process.

The Hluttaw could have been involved proactively on the communal conflicts. There were avenues for dialogue between Rakhine and Muslim legislators, but they were never realized at a formal level. The legislators could have played a mediator role in the crisis, but instead they were even accused of escalating the crisis.[16] It was weak and ineffective in responding to conflict due to its sensitivity and constraints. At the very least, it was able to prevent itself from negatively influencing the conflicts by rejecting radical motions and toning down sensitive bills.

ANALYSING THE RESPONSE

These three case studies together reflect the characteristics of the Hluttaw in responding to various conflicts, and reveal its institutional strengths and weaknesses. As mentioned in the introduction, these conflicts differed from each other. Yet there were a number of approaches repeatedly taken by the legislature such as the non-partisan approach, the use of questions and motions, and the influence of the speakers. Whether in a transitional or established legislature and regardless of institutional constraints, lawmakers can play a crucial role in their societies and strengthen peace-building through consultation and mediation (Miall, Ramsbotham, and Woodhouse 2003, p. 216). And yet, Myanmar's legislature was not able to use its consultation mechanism effectively. There was no formal interaction between lawmakers and very little with concerned stakeholders.

Non-partisan legislature

One reason the Hluttaw spoke with one voice in responding to these three conflicts was the non-partisan nature of the legislature. In all three cases, the